

Smile Enhancement After-Care Guide

Separate instructions for Veneers, Smile Designing, Composite Aesthetic Fillings, Tooth Whitening & Cosmetic Contouring

Each treatment has its own dedicated after-care section. Your dentist's personalised instructions always take priority.

Dental Veneers

After-care following placement of porcelain or ceramic veneers

WHAT IS NORMAL?

Mild sensitivity to cold or pressure can occur for a short time. The gums may also feel slightly tender while they settle around the new veneers.

REMEMBER

Veneers are strong but thin restorations. Protect them from excessive forces and maintain excellent oral hygiene.

1. Eating and drinking

- Follow your dentist's instructions regarding when normal eating can begin after cementation.
- For the first day, avoid very hard or sticky foods if the veneers or surrounding gums feel tender.
- Do not bite ice, pens, nails or other hard objects with veneered teeth.

2. Protect the veneers

- Do not use your front teeth to tear packets, open containers or bite non-food objects.
- If you clench or grind your teeth, ask your dentist whether a protective night guard is appropriate.
- Avoid habits that repeatedly put excessive pressure on the veneers.

3. Oral hygiene

- Brush twice daily with fluoride toothpaste and clean between the teeth every day.
- Clean gently along the gumline around the veneers.
- Healthy gums help maintain the appearance and longevity of veneers.

4. Appearance and sensitivity

- Minor sensitivity may settle as the tooth adapts.
- Colour matching can look slightly different under different lighting conditions.
- Do not attempt to polish or alter the veneer yourself.

5. Contact your dentist if

- A veneer feels loose, chipped or fractured.
- Pain or sensitivity is severe or persistent.
- Your bite feels high or uncomfortable.
- There is persistent gum swelling or bleeding.

Smile Designing

After-care following digital or planned smile-design treatment

WHAT IS NORMAL?

It can take time to get used to changes in tooth shape, length, position or the way your lips and cheeks feel around the teeth.

REMEMBER

Smile design is customised to your face, teeth and bite. Protect the planned result by following the specific instructions for the treatment used.

1. Adjusting to the new smile

- Allow yourself time to adapt to changes in tooth shape and bite.
- Speech may feel slightly different initially, especially after changes to the front teeth.
- Do not repeatedly test the new bite by clenching hard.

2. Eating

- Start with softer foods if chewing feels unfamiliar.
- Gradually return to normal foods as advised by your dentist.
- Avoid very hard or sticky foods if temporary restorations are present.

3. Daily care

- Brush twice daily and clean between teeth every day.
- Follow any additional cleaning instructions for veneers, crowns, bonding or other restorations used in your smile design.
- Keep the gums healthy to maintain the appearance of the smile.

4. Protect the result

- Avoid biting hard objects and using the teeth as tools.
- If grinding or clenching is present, discuss a protective night guard.
- Maintain regular dental examinations and professional cleaning as advised.

5. Contact your dentist if

- Your bite feels persistently uneven or uncomfortable.
- A temporary or permanent restoration becomes loose or damaged.
- Persistent pain, sensitivity or gum irritation develops.

Composite Aesthetic Fillings

After-care following tooth-coloured composite bonding or aesthetic fillings

WHAT IS NORMAL?

Mild sensitivity to cold can occur briefly. The restored tooth may feel slightly different until you become accustomed to it.

REMEMBER

Composite restorations look natural, but they can chip, stain or wear if exposed to excessive forces or habits.

1. Eating after treatment

- If local anaesthetic was used, wait until numbness has completely worn off before eating.
- Follow your dentist's advice about when to eat normally.
- Avoid very hard or sticky foods if the restoration feels tender.

2. Protect the composite

- Do not bite ice, pens, nails or other hard objects.
- Avoid using restored front teeth to tear packets or bite non-food items.
- If you grind or clench, discuss protective options with your dentist.

3. Maintain the appearance

- Brush twice daily and clean between the teeth.
- Tea, coffee, tobacco and strongly coloured foods can contribute to staining over time.
- Do not use abrasive products or attempt to polish the restoration yourself.

4. Sensitivity or bite

- Temporary sensitivity can occur and should generally settle.
- If the filling feels too high or the tooth hurts when biting, contact your dentist for assessment.
- Do not attempt to adjust the restoration yourself.

5. Contact your dentist if

- The composite chips, fractures or comes out.
- Pain or sensitivity persists or worsens.
- The restoration feels high or interferes with your bite.

Tooth Whitening

After-care following professional tooth whitening

WHAT IS NORMAL?

Temporary sensitivity to cold is common after whitening. The gums may also feel mildly irritated if whitening material has contacted them.

REMEMBER

The whitening effect is maintained by good oral hygiene and sensible dietary habits. Whitening does not change the colour of existing crowns, veneers or fillings.

1. First 24–48 hours

- If your dentist recommends it, limit strongly coloured foods and drinks during the early period after whitening.
- Choose lighter-coloured foods if sensitivity is present.
- Avoid very hot or very cold foods if they trigger discomfort.

2. Sensitivity

- Use a desensitising toothpaste if recommended by your dentist.
- Temporary sensitivity should usually settle.
- If sensitivity is severe or persistent, contact your dentist.

3. Protect your results

- Brush twice daily with fluoride toothpaste.
- Limit frequent exposure to staining drinks such as tea, coffee and coloured beverages.
- Do not repeat whitening treatments more often than recommended.

4. Important to know

- Whitening changes natural tooth colour; it does not whiten existing crowns, veneers, bridges or composite fillings.
- Restorations may therefore appear different in shade after whitening and may need assessment before replacement.

5. Contact your dentist if

- Severe sensitivity develops.
- Burning or persistent gum irritation occurs.
- You notice unusual pain or symptoms that do not settle.

Cosmetic Contouring

After-care following cosmetic tooth contouring or enamel reshaping

WHAT IS NORMAL?

Minor sensitivity can occur if a small amount of enamel has been reshaped. The tooth may feel different to your tongue initially.

REMEMBER

Cosmetic contouring involves carefully reshaping tooth surfaces. Do not try to reproduce or alter the shape yourself.

1. Eating and chewing

- Normal eating is usually possible unless your dentist gives different instructions.
- Avoid biting very hard objects or using the teeth as tools.
- If the tooth feels tender, choose softer foods temporarily.

2. Sensitivity

- Mild temporary sensitivity may occur.
- Use a desensitising toothpaste if recommended.
- Contact your dentist if sensitivity is severe or persists.

3. Protect the new shape

- Do not bite pens, nails, ice or other hard objects.
- If you grind or clench, discuss protective options with your dentist.
- Maintain regular brushing and interdental cleaning.

4. Your bite and appearance

- The reshaped tooth may feel different for a short time while your tongue adapts.
- If your bite feels uneven or uncomfortable, contact your dentist for assessment.

5. Contact your dentist if

- Persistent pain or sensitivity develops.
- Your bite feels noticeably different or uncomfortable.
- A tooth chips or develops a sharp edge.

General Smile-Care Information

Protecting your smile

Good daily brushing, cleaning between the teeth, healthy gums and avoidance of excessive biting forces are important for maintaining cosmetic dental work. Your individual treatment plan may require additional instructions.

When to contact your dentist

Seek dental advice for persistent pain, significant sensitivity, swelling, a loose or damaged restoration, a sudden change in your bite, or any symptom that is not improving.

References

1. American Dental Association. Oral Health Topics: Whitening. Patient information.
2. American Dental Association. Oral Health Topics: Veneers and cosmetic dentistry. Patient information.
3. American College of Prosthodontists. Patient information on veneers, crowns and restorative care.
4. American Academy of Cosmetic Dentistry. Patient education resources on cosmetic dental procedures.